

Spartan Design VIQRC Competitive Elective Student & Family Handbook

Foreword

This handbook explains the learning, safety, participation, competition, and documentation expectations for the Spartan Design VEX IQ Robotics Competition (VIQRC) competitive elective at Mary R. Stauffer Middle School. It is reviewed each year by the coach and may be updated as school, VEX Robotics, or Global Robotics & Science Foundation requirements change.

Students and families are expected to follow this handbook, the school code of conduct, and the current VIQRC Game Manual. Ms. Lang may revise procedures to protect student safety, learning, or event readiness. Material changes will be communicated through Canvas.

This VIQRC edition was adapted from an earlier Spartan Design competitive robotics handbook and the Warren Warbots handbook that informed it. Competition rules are summarized for orientation only; the current official VIQRC Game Manual and official Q&A always control.

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1. Introduction & Objectives

Spartan Design is a year-long VIQRC competitive elective for middle school students. Teams design, build, program, test, document, and operate VEX IQ robots while learning engineering, collaboration, strategy, and professional communication.

1.1. MISSION STATEMENT

To serve as an inspiring team that aspires members to learn, grow, and collaborate.

1.2. TEAM OVERVIEW

Students attend Mary R. Stauffer Middle School and work in six-person competition teams. Each team develops one legal VEX IQ robot and an engineering notebook that tells the evidence-based story of its design process, programming, strategy, testing, and iteration.

The Spartans also prioritize our impact on our community through events that teach and inspire young students to pursue STEM fields. The team aspires to partner with local companies to provide professional insight into the industry. The team also strives to increase the diversity in STEM by working with communities in the area.

Course materials, milestones, announcements, and submissions are maintained in Canvas. VEX Robotics publishes the game and rules; the Global Robotics & Science Foundation provides the officially authorized competition pathway and team resources.

2. VIQRC Overview

2.1. GLOBAL ROBOTICS & SCIENCE FOUNDATION

The Global Robotics & Science Foundation is the officially authorized nonprofit partner for VEX Robotics competitions and the exclusive pathway for teams qualifying to the VEX Robotics World Championship. VIQRC teams are expected to demonstrate teamwork, respectful conduct, authentic student work, and an iterative engineering process.

Official competition rules, judging guidance, event qualification pathways, and student-centered policies can change during the season. Teams must verify current information before every event.

2.2. VEX IQ ROBOTICS COMPETITION

VIQRC is a middle-school-friendly competition using snap-together VEX IQ components. In Teamwork Matches, two teams form an alliance and cooperate for 60 seconds to earn the highest combined score. Teams also compete independently in Driving Skills and Autonomous Coding Skills. Events may include engineering-notebook review and student interviews for judged awards.

2.3. 2026-2027 GAME: LEVEL UP

The 2026-2027 game is Level Up. Version 1.1, released August 6, 2026, is this handbook's verified baseline. Robots score Bean Bags in Goals on a 6-by-8-foot field during 60-second matches. Floor, Levels 1-4 are worth 1, 3, 6, 12, and 16 points respectively; Level 4 accepts yellow Bean Bags only.

The current game creates connected design problems: reliable one-Bean-Bag control (<SG6>), legal loading (<SG7>), efficient navigation, and fast scoring at useful goal heights. The robot must fit within 11 inches wide by 20 inches long by 15 inches high during inspection and at the start (<R3>), and may use no more than six VEX IQ Smart Motors (<R9>), one battery (<R10>), and one controller (<R11>).

- Teamwork strategy must help both Robots contribute without blocking one another. Qualification ranking uses average Teamwork scores and events conclude with Finals Matches.
- Robot Skills strategy must include repeatable Driving Skills and Autonomous Coding Skills routines supported by measured testing. In Autonomous Coding Skills, teams may handle and legally reset the Robot, but do not receive a new Preload (<RSC5>).

Game Manual and Update Cycle

- The Game Manual is updated throughout the season. The team will seed its dated rules-change log with Version 1.1 (August 6, 2026) and recheck inspection, scoring, Drive Team, loading, and match procedures before each event.
- The official VIQRC Q&A is binding for rule interpretations. Students should cite the manual rule or Q&A used when a design or strategy decision depends on it.
- No handbook summary replaces the current official rules.

Competition Year

- August-October: learn Level Up, build fundamentals, prototype, and establish baseline Driving and Autonomous Coding Skills scores.
- November-February: compete locally, analyze match data, complete repeated design cycles, and pursue judged-award readiness.
- March-May: prepare qualified teams for championships, complete a season retrospective, and transfer knowledge to returning members.

3. Team Overview

The competitive elective is designed for multiple six-student teams, including approximately six or seven returning members who will be distributed across teams as peer leaders. Team assignments are made to balance experience, communication, and learning needs.

3.1. SIX-PERSON TEAM COMPOSITION

Each competition team has six students organized into three role pairs. Every pair has one lead and one backup. 'Backup' means fully trained second specialist, not substitute or assistant.

Drivers: lead driver and backup driver.

- Programmers: lead programmer and backup programmer.
- Strategists: lead strategist and backup strategist.
- All six students share responsibility for safe construction, inspection readiness, testing, cleanup, and engineering-notebook evidence.
- At events, Ms. Lang confirms the students assigned to each match, skills run, pit task, and interview based on current rules and demonstrated readiness. A VIQRC match Drive Team may include Driver 1, Driver 2, and a Loader; these event positions are distinct from the classroom specialty pairs.
- Leads coordinate work and teach their backup. Backups independently rehearse the same core tasks and must be able to assume the lead role when needed.
- Role titles do not give ownership of the robot, code, strategy, or notebook. All competition work belongs to the team.

Adult Coach and Volunteers

- Ms. Lang manages instruction, safety, schedules, family communication, and event decisions.
- Adults may teach skills, ask questions, provide feedback, and enforce safety. Students must make and explain the team's design, build, programming, strategy, and notebook decisions.

3.2. PROGRAM LEADERSHIP

Program leadership consists of Ms. Lang, designated school staff, approved adult volunteers, and student leads. The coach retains final authority for safety, eligibility, team assignments, travel, and competition readiness.

3.2.1. Coach

The coach establishes milestones, approves safe work, monitors student-centered practice, coordinates events, and communicates with students and families through school-approved systems.

3.2.2. Student Leads

Each role lead plans work with the backup, communicates status to the whole team, and makes sure evidence is captured in the engineering notebook. Leadership is demonstrated through preparation, teaching, listening, and follow-through.

3.2.3. Adult Mentors and Volunteers

Approved mentors and volunteers may support instruction, event logistics, field practice, and supervision under the direction of Ms. Lang and school policy.

3.2.4. Student-Centered Support

Adults must not design, build, program, document, or make match decisions for students. Students should be able to explain what they tried, what the data showed, and why they chose the current solution.

3.3. ROLE PAIRS

Every team uses the same three-pair structure. Pair assignments are based on interest, demonstrated readiness, team balance, and growth goals. Assignments may be reviewed at grading-period milestones, but changes must protect continuity before events.

3.3.1. Drivers: Lead and Backup

Both drivers train with the controller, complete Teamwork and Driving Skills routines, and communicate calmly with Teamwork partners. Under <GG11>, Drivers switch the controller between 0:35 and 0:25 remaining and neither may operate for more than 35 seconds. The lead coordinates practice; the backup must be competition-ready.

3.3.2. Programmers: Lead and Backup

Both programmers maintain organized VEXcode IQ projects, calibrate sensors, document versions, test repeatably, and prepare Autonomous Coding Skills routines. The lead coordinates integration; the backup must be able to explain, debug, and run the current code.

3.3.3. Strategists: Lead and Backup

Both strategists maintain the rules-change log, collect scouting and skills data, prepare Teamwork partner plans, rehearse legal loading with assigned Loaders, and lead post-match review. They also verify that claims in the engineering notebook are supported by evidence.

- Shared Build and Pit Work
- All six students build and maintain the Robot. Before events, the team verifies the 11-by-20-by-15-inch inspected start size, six-motor maximum, legal VEX IQ parts, one battery, one controller, firmware, license plates, spares, and current inspection readiness.

Shared Notebook Work

Every student contributes dated evidence. One student may format or assemble an entry, but the notebook must represent the team's authentic work and collective reasoning.

3.4. RETURNING MEMBERS AND ONBOARDING

Returning members are distributed across teams when possible so that experience is shared. Returning status does not guarantee a lead role, preferred robot, or competition assignment.

3.4.1. Distributed Leadership

Returning members model safe construction, productive testing, respectful feedback, careful notebook habits, and student-centered decision making.

Each returning member receives a defined onboarding responsibility, such as drivetrain construction, VEXcode setup, controller practice, rules navigation, or notebook evidence.

New members are expected to ask questions, practice deliberately, document learning, and gradually complete tasks without prompts.

The goal is capability across the whole team, not dependence on one experienced student.

3.4.2. Cross-Training

During the opening weeks, students rotate through driving, programming, strategy, construction, and notebook tasks before primary roles are finalized.

After roles are assigned, backups practice the same essential workflows as their leads. Teams schedule regular role-swap drills so an absence does not stop progress.

Cross-training does not mean changing jobs randomly during event preparation. The coach may freeze match and skills assignments when consistency is needed.

- 3.4.3. Readiness Checks
- Students demonstrate readiness through short practical checks: build a reliable mechanism, explain a code segment, complete a controlled driving route, locate and apply a rule, present notebook evidence, or lead a post-test review.

The coach may require additional practice before a student operates the robot at an event or represents the team in an interview.

Safety and respectful conduct are always part of readiness.

3.4.4. Role Review

- Role assignments are reviewed at grading-period milestones and after major events. Reviews consider preparation, attendance, collaboration, documentation, growth, and performance under realistic conditions.
- A lead may become a backup and a backup may become a lead when the change supports learning and team readiness.

The coach will communicate role changes privately and provide a clear improvement target.

Team Continuity

Each pair keeps a shared task list and version record so work can continue when one member is absent.

Drivers record practice goals and scores.

Programmers record code versions, test conditions, and results.

Strategists record rules, match plans, scouting observations, and retrospectives.

All pairs link their evidence to the team's current design priorities.

- Leadership Evidence
- Leads document what they taught and delegated; backups document what they can now perform independently.
- No team member should be the only person who knows how a critical mechanism, program, or event process works.
- Conflict Resolution
- Students first describe the problem using observable facts, listen to each viewpoint, identify the shared goal, and agree on a testable next step.
- If a disagreement affects safety, dignity, or continued progress, students pause and ask the coach for help.

The coach makes the final decision when the team cannot reach a safe, timely resolution.

4. Team Participation Requirements

4.1. SUMMARY

The following summarizes the quantitative requirements described in the later sections:

- Must maintain a 3.0 or greater GPA
- Must be passing all courses
- Must attend a majority of team meetings

4.2. APPLICATION PROCESS

All students (returning and new members) must apply each year to be an official team member of Spartan Design for the upcoming season. The leadership team evaluates applicants and invites selected students to be a part of the team. Eligibility is determined by input on the application.

4.2.1. Participant Release

All team participants must complete the current event consent or participant-release process required for official VEX Robotics events. Ms. Lang will provide the current instructions and verify completion through events.vex.com before participation.

Note: Teams will not be allowed to turn in hardcopy forms at events. All Participant Release forms must be completed online or submitted via hard copies uploaded by the coach.

4.3. ACADEMIC PERFORMANCE

VIQRC requires consistent preparation during class, practices, and competition days. The course is designed to help students balance this commitment with their other classes and personal responsibilities.

4.3.1. Academic Progress Reports

The coach will monitor academic progress, school attendance, and conduct using school procedures. Concerns will be discussed with the student and, when appropriate, the family, teachers, counselor, or administration so that a support plan can be created.

4.3.2. Grade Requirement

Students must meet the school and district eligibility rules communicated by the coach. The coach will use progress reports and family communication to create support plans before academic concerns become barriers.

Students not meeting these criteria during the application period will be ineligible to join our team. Students whose grades fall while on the team will be discouraged from attending meetings in the interest of focusing on school work and will not be eligible to travel.

Note, it is ultimately the students' and parents' responsibility to frequently monitor grades, make the appropriate attendance choices, and adjust commitments as needed to ensure success in school.

4.4. TIME COMMITMENT

Students are expected to use class time productively and attend announced practices and events needed for their team's milestones. Research, notebook reflection, and approved coding practice may also be completed outside class.

All enrolled students are full members of a six-person VIQRC team. Additional after-school participation and event roles are assigned by the coach based on supervision, transportation, safety, and readiness.

4.4.1. Attendance Tracking

Attendance will be tracked through Canvas or another school-approved method identified by the coach.

4.4.2. Continual Presence

While considered to be in attendance at a team meeting, team members' locations must be continually accounted for. Therefore, students are required to stay within the boundaries of team meetings at ALL times during the meeting hours unless they are being picked up early and have notified a Supervising Mentor.

4.4.3. Tardiness & Absences

A team member who needs to arrive late, leave early, or be absent from a meeting or event must inform the mentors and students they are working with in advance.

Students who expect recurring tardiness or absences should notify Ms. Lang and their team as early as possible so responsibilities can be transferred safely.

Students should be aware that regular tardiness or absences reduce their eligibility for the travel team, leadership positions, and other heavier-time-commitment roles such as the drive team.

4.4.4. Game Reveal and Season Kickoff (May)

The regular meeting times are as follows:

- Tuesday, 3:00 PM – 5:00 PM
- Thursday, 3:00 PM – 5:00 PM
- Any schedule change will be communicated as early as possible through the course calendar and Canvas.

Throughout the preseason, there may be additional meetings to allow for focused progress (such as driver practice) or events.

4.4.5. Summer Camp

Teams will attend summer camp at the designated school. Camp hours are 8:00 AM – 12:00 PM, Monday through Friday, over the following three weeks:

- Week 1: June 22nd – June 26th (5 days)
- Week 2: June 29th – July 2nd (4 days)
- Week 3: July 6th – July 7th (2 days)

Students may not enroll in both the district's academic summer school and robotics summer camp. Because the two programs run concurrently during the same weeks, attempting to do both would cause students to miss a significant number of robotics days before the regular team schedule begins. Families should choose one program and commit to it fully.

4.4.6. Season Schedule

During Competition Season, the team typically has two weekday meetings per week, with occasional Saturday meetings scheduled as needed:

- Tuesdays, 3:00 PM – 5:00 PM
- Thursdays, 3:00 PM – 5:00 PM
- Saturdays, 8:00 AM – 12:00 PM — approximately once per month or as scheduled, typically in the weeks leading up to a competition
- Additional meetings will be scheduled as needed

Attendance is part of team readiness. The coach will publish required practices and events in advance and will work with families on documented conflicts. Repeated avoidable absences may change a student's event or role assignment.

4.5. REMOVAL FROM THE TEAM

If a student does not meet the expectations in this handbook, the coach will use the school's progressive support and discipline procedures. Immediate safety or serious conduct concerns may require removal from an activity while the matter is reviewed.

- Students will receive a verbal warning
- If a student fails to correct their actions, the student and their guardian will receive a follow-up email warning including corrective measures based on the infraction.
- The number of warnings a student may receive before dismissal will be subject to the severity of the infraction(s) and administrative guidance.

Note: Severe infractions can be subject to immediate dismissal from the team.

Note: School administration has the authority to remove students from the team as disciplinary action.

4.6. YEAR-LONG VIQRC COMPETITIVE ELECTIVE

The course combines engineering design, construction, programming, strategy, documentation, and competition operations. Daily work is organized around team deliverables rather than isolated role grades.

4.6.1. Engineering Design and Construction

Students use a repeatable engineering design process: identify a problem and constraints; research and brainstorm multiple alternatives; select with criteria and evidence; build or program the simplest testable version; run controlled, repeatable tests; interpret failures and results; and iterate. All construction must use legal VEX IQ components and current Robot rules.

4.6.2. Programming and Robot Skills

Students use VEXcode IQ to develop reliable driver-control features and Autonomous Coding Skills routines. Programming evidence includes readable versions, pseudocode or flow planning, test data, debugging notes, and conclusions.

4.6.3. Grading-Period Notebook Milestones

At each middle-school grading period, teams submit a notebook checkpoint documenting the current problem, at least three alternatives when appropriate, the selection rationale, labeled sketches/photos/code, raw trial data, what the evidence means, failed ideas, rule citations, individual contributions, the team decision, and the next controlled test. Every entry is dated and names its contributors. Teams duplicate template entry pages for each meaningful build, code, test, event, or iteration; the final checkpoint includes a season retrospective and knowledge-transfer plan.

4.6.4. Returning-Member Expectations

- Returning members must demonstrate growth beyond repeating last year's solution. Their evidence should show teaching, deeper analysis, stronger testing, and responsible delegation.
- 4.6.5. Support and Accessibility
- Students who need an accommodation, alternative access method, or additional practice should speak with the coach. Supports will preserve safety, student ownership, and the essential learning goals of the course.

Assessment Balance

Grades reflect individual preparation and reflection as well as team deliverables. Competition rank alone is not a grade.

A robot failure can still produce strong evidence of learning when the team documents the failure accurately, analyzes causes, and proposes a justified next test.

- A high match score does not replace missing design reasoning or notebook evidence.
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5. Parent/Guardian Involvement

Robotics is an expensive, yet highly rewarding, program due to the cost of materials, equipment/tools, repairs, facilities requirements, competition fees, team members and equipment transportation, lodging, and meals.

No student will be disqualified or dismissed from the team for lack of parent/guardian involvement, donations, and/or volunteer hours.

5.1. FUNDRAISERS

The program may host VIQRC events or other approved fundraisers. All fundraising, fees, concessions, and donations must follow school and district procedures.

Because team members are already extremely busy between robotics, school, and other obligations, other fundraising activities conducted by the team will be limited. Members and families are, however, encouraged to participate in occasional additional fundraising events when they are scheduled.

Fundraising priorities may include VEX IQ parts, game and field elements, event registration, transportation, and approved championship travel.

5.2. VOLUNTEERING

Competitions and hosted events depend on approved adult volunteers. The coach will publish specific needs, required screening or training, arrival times, and supervision responsibilities.

Families are invited to support the program in ways that fit their availability. Volunteer opportunities may include:

- Providing transportation to and from events
- Organizing meals for students and mentors during competitions
- Event-day volunteer roles at hosted tournaments — check-in, scorekeeping assistance, queueing, concessions, setup, and breakdown
- Supporting team activities such as building field elements

Families should contact Ms. Lang through school communication channels before arranging transportation, donations, event work, or outside support on behalf of the program.

5.3. SPONSORSHIP AND DONATIONS

Spartan Design relies on community partnerships to expand access to VEX IQ equipment, event registration, field elements, transportation, and student learning opportunities. Sponsors support the educational program; they do not direct student design or competition decisions.

5.3.1. Why Sponsor Spartan Design VIQRC

Sponsorship is an investment in middle school STEM learning in Downey. Students gain hands-on experience in engineering, programming, communication, project management, and evidence-based problem solving.

Sponsors also gain direct visibility with the hundreds of students, families, coaches, and visitors who attend the qualifier tournaments we host at Stauffer Middle School each season (see §5.1 and §6.4).

5.3.2. What Sponsorships and Donations Support

Funds raised through sponsorships and donations are used to support, among other things:

- Robot parts, electronics, and replacement components
- Team-wide consumables such as batteries, fasteners, and tools
- Competition registration fees
- Travel, lodging, and meal costs for out-of-area competitions, including Signature Events and the VEX Robotics World Championship when the team qualifies
- Team shirts, pit materials, and promotional items
- Engineering notebook and documentation supplies
- Facility equipment, shop tools, and maintenance

5.3.3. Sponsor Recognition Tiers

Recognition levels and benefits must be approved by the school before they are promised or published. The coach will provide current sponsorship materials upon request.

Bronze — \$100 to \$250

- Name listed on the team's thank-you post
- Certificate of appreciation
- Mentioned at the end-of-season recap

Silver — \$250 to \$500

- All Bronze benefits
- Logo placement on the team banner
- Logo placement on the team's engineering notebook cover
- Mid-season update email with team progress

Gold — \$500 to \$1,000

- All Silver benefits
- Approved logo recognition on team materials or robot identification, subject to school approval and current VIQRC rules

- Feature post on team social media
- Invitation to an on-site robot demonstration at Stauffer Middle School
- Post-season results report sent to the sponsor

Worlds Sponsor — \$1,000 and above

- All Gold benefits
- Primary logo placement on the robot
- Named in team competition announcements
- Photo set from the championship event
- Individual thank-you letters from each student on the team

Any logo placed on a robot must comply with current VIQRC robot-identification rules and receive coach approval. In-kind donations are valued and acknowledged through school-approved procedures.

Before pursuing private sponsorship outreach, families and students should consult the coach about current VEX Robotics or Global Robotics funding resources and school-approved fundraising pathways.

5.3.4. Individual Donations

Individual donations may support the program only through school-approved procedures. Families and community members should contact Ms. Lang through official school channels before sending funds or materials.

5.3.5. How to Sponsor or Donate

To discuss sponsorship, donations, or volunteer support, contact Ms. Lang through Mary R. Stauffer Middle School's official communication channels.

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ATTN: Ms. Lang - Spartan Design VIQRC

The program is grateful to every sponsor, donor, volunteer, and family who helps students participate in meaningful competitive robotics experiences.

6. Travel Team

The event calendar may include local tournaments, league sessions, championships, and other approved VIQRC events. Travel participation depends on qualification, school approval, supervision, transportation, academic eligibility, conduct, and readiness.

Participation in overnight travel is not a required activity for the team. Our overnight travel team is not always the size of our overall team and is subject to administrative approval.

The following sections outline the requirements for the Travel Team:

6.1. ACADEMIC STANDING

Students must meet current school and district extracurricular eligibility requirements.

6.2. ATTENDANCE

Students must both attend and be productive during team meetings.

With the limited number of spots available on our travel team, selections may be made by the types of skills and knowledge necessary to ensure the success of the team during the competition.

6.3. LOCAL COMPETITIONS

Local events within reasonable travel distance provide the primary competition experience. The coach will communicate transportation, check-in, supervision, meals, and pickup procedures for each event.

6.4. QUALIFIER TOURNAMENTS

Qualifier tournaments commonly include Teamwork Challenge qualification matches ranked by average score, Teamwork Finals Matches, Driving and Autonomous Coding Skills opportunities, and judged awards. Qualification pathways and award allocations vary by event and season; the team will verify them at events.vex.com and in current Global Robotics competition resources.

The coach assigns each attending team and event support role. Students prepare for inspection, matches, skills runs, alliance communication, judging, scouting, pit organization, and cleanup.

6.5. VIQRC LEAGUE EVENTS

A VIQRC league holds ranking sessions over multiple dates and concludes with League Finals. Leagues provide repeated competition and time for evidence-based iteration between sessions.

The coach assigns attending teams and event roles. Students not operating a robot may support inspection, pit organization, alliance communication, scouting, notebook readiness, or approved volunteering.

6.6. SIGNATURE EVENTS

Signature Events offer a high-quality multi-region competition experience using VIQRC Teamwork Challenge, Robot Skills, and judged-award formats.

Signature Events are open to eligible registered teams and may involve significant registration, travel, and lodging costs. Teams will verify current eligibility and championship-qualification details through events.vex.com and current Global Robotics competition resources before registering.

Attendance at a Signature Event requires a specific educational, financial, supervision, and readiness plan approved by the coach and school.

6.7. EVENT REGION (REGIONAL) CHAMPIONSHIP

The Event Region Championship — also called the Regional, State, or equivalent Championship depending on the region — is the capstone event of the local qualifying season. Teams qualify for this championship through championship-qualifying awards at qualifier tournaments, through League Finals, or through world skills rankings. Championship-qualifying awards at the Event Region Championship qualify teams directly for the VEX Robotics World Championship.

When a team qualifies for the Event Region Championship, the coach will identify the competition roster and support roles using the same eligibility and readiness criteria described in this handbook.

6.8. VEX ROBOTICS WORLD CHAMPIONSHIP

The VEX Robotics World Championship is the culminating VIQRC event. Qualification methods are published through the authorized VEX Robotics and Global Robotics pathway and may include championship-qualifying awards, skills rankings, or other season-specific pathways.

World Championship participation requires qualification plus school approval, travel planning, eligibility, conduct, and demonstrated event readiness.

7. Team Conduct & Guidelines

Each student represents Spartan Design, Stauffer Middle School, teammates, families, sponsors, volunteers, and the broader VIQRC community through their words and actions.

7.1. TEAM VALUES

7.1.1. VEX Core Values

Current Global Robotics judging and competition resources, together with school expectations, guide student ownership, teamwork, integrity, respect, inclusion, safety, and responsible conduct in competition and classroom work.

Teamwork and Collaboration: Students work together, share ideas, and solve problems as a team.

Innovation and Creativity: Encourages designing and engineering unique solutions to challenges.

Problem-Solving and Critical Thinking: Students learn to tackle complex problems through trial and error, iteration, and strategy.

Sportsmanship and Respect: Teams are expected to compete ethically, respect their opponents, and show gracious professionalism (similar to the spirit of other robotics programs).

Student-Centered Learning: The students do the designing, building, and programming — not the adults or mentors.

Perseverance and Resilience: Failing, improving, and trying again is seen as essential to the engineering process.

Each year, the Spartan Design VIQRC program strives to incorporate these values into all aspects of its program, reflects upon how it has implemented these values, and considers where improvements can be made.

7.1.2. Learning Through Failure

Everyone fails, and it is vital that students know how to deal with failure. the Spartan Design VIQRC program aims to show students that instead of dwelling on their failure, they should seek to understand what went wrong, how to prevent it from happening again, and then apply their newfound knowledge to not make the same error again. Students will be given tasks that challenge them and the space to make mistakes while still receiving support from their peers and mentors.

7.1.3. Spartan Design Philosophy — Think. Build. Adapt. Lead.

the Spartan Design VIQRC program operates under a four-pillar philosophy that shapes how the team competes, builds, and carries itself. Each pillar is rooted in a classical thinker whose ideas inform how students approach both robotics and the challenges of life beyond it.

Think - Study Level Up, the current rules, scoring paths, partner needs, and test data before choosing a design or match plan.

Build - Create the simplest reliable VEX IQ solution that meets the team's measured requirements. Every mechanism should have a clear purpose.

Adapt - Observe results, interpret evidence, decide on the next test, and act quickly without hiding failure or blaming teammates.

Lead - Control preparation, attitude, communication, and the next useful action, especially when a robot or match does not go as planned.

7.1.4. The Seven Values

the Spartan Design VIQRC program practices seven values that translate the Philosophy into daily habits. These values are rehearsed in practice so they become automatic at tournaments:

Know the Battlefield. Study the game. Scout every opponent. Plan with real data, not guesses.

Build with Purpose. Use legal VEX IQ parts to create simple, strong, serviceable mechanisms tied to a scoring or reliability requirement.

Strike with Speed. Act quickly and efficiently. Drive clean. Score early. Pressure opponents with pace.

Adapt or Lose. Be flexible. Change strategies when the match changes. Rigid plans break; adaptable teams win.

Stay Calm Under Fire. Control the mindset. Focus under pressure. The match does not change because you are nervous — but you can.

Honor the Team. Respect every role. Lead with integrity. Work together — the robot wins, not any one person.

Master the Loop. Observe. Orient. Decide. Act. Learn, improve, repeat. Every match teaches something.

7.1.5. The Spartan Creed

The Spartan Creed is the six-line statement every team member commits to — on and off the field. It captures what the Spartan Design VIQRC program is at its core:

- We think before we act. Every move is planned. Every plan is studied. We win the match before the match begins.
- We act without fear. When the plan is set, we commit. Hesitation loses matches. Confidence wins them.
- We adapt without ego. When things go wrong, we fix them. We do not blame teammates. We do not blame the robot. We adjust.
- We compete with honor. We respect every opponent, every alliance partner, every judge, every volunteer. Always.
- We improve without end. Every practice, every match, every build. There is always something to learn and something to fix.
- We are Spartan Design.

7.2. CODE OF CONDUCT

7.2.1. Everywhere

When wearing the team shirt or logo, students are representing Spartan Design and Stauffer Middle School. What is said to another team member and how it is said may be overheard by a judge, potential sponsor, teacher, or administrator. Even facial expressions and body language may bring unwanted negative attention and make bad impressions. Any guests invited or brought to competitions or the team's work area must understand this and behave accordingly. All actions taken as a team member or supporter are directly reflected in the team's image.

7.2.2. Traveling

Whether traveling for a competition or an outreach event, the following rules must be followed at all times:

- To travel to amenities within proximity of the lodging, students are required to travel in groups of three or more students and have the explicit permission of a chaperone, who needs to know who is going, where they are going, when they plan to get back, and their cell phone numbers.
- All students are required to be in their rooms by curfew and not allowed to leave until dawn, except in case of an emergency. Unless specified at the team meetings at a competition or there is a team meeting (ex: strategy discussion), the curfew is 10 PM. If the team needs to depart from the accommodations early in the morning, team members may leave their rooms at a reasonable time in order to support the departure time.

7.2.3. Competition Boundaries

All team members in attendance at a competition are required to stay within the predefined boundaries at ALL TIMES. Team members may not leave the boundaries for ANY reason unless express permission is given by mentors or an adult chaperone.

Once at a competition, team members are expected to be participating in the following ways:

- Any other action must be cleared by the coach or assigned chaperone. Canvas and school-approved contact procedures will be used for event communication.
- Performing a volunteer role at the event (field reset, queuing, etc.).
- Interacting with other teams in the pit area or around the field.
- In the team section of the stands, watching matches and cheering for teams.

Any other action must be cleared by the coach or assigned chaperone. Canvas and school-approved contact procedures will be used for event communication.

7.2.4. Competition Expectations

Throughout the entire competition, the following are required:

- Students must be in their assigned team area for matches, skills runs, interviews, and ceremonies unless completing an approved task. Everyone helps with setup, inspection, field reset when assigned, pit organization, loading, and cleanup.
- Stay with the group. If a team member wants to go anywhere other than where they should be, they must inform a chaperone and find a reasonable time to do so. If a team member is needed and cannot be located, it will reflect poorly on them.
- Stay on task and fulfill assigned roles and responsibilities. Everyone is needed! Failure to do so may result in the revocation of one's travel privileges.

7.2.5. Team Matches and Awards

Meal and off-site procedures will be communicated for each event. Middle school students may not leave the event boundary without explicit permission and required adult supervision.

7.2.6. Team Spirit

Attendance at competitions is a privilege. Team members are there to cheer on the team and the team's alliances, interact with friends from around the world and learn. When someone is speaking, team members are to give them their undivided attention. When the team is on the field, all team members should be actively cheering and focusing on the game. When there is downtime, team members should explore the competition, talk with other teams, or watch/learn from the matches. Excessive idle behavior (such as playing card games or video games, or having side conversations) during competition may deem a team member ineligible for future travel with the team. Each member's behavior reflects on the team and is also a factor in several awards distributed during the competition.

7.2.7. Meals at Competitions

All team members in attendance at a competition are required to participate in the group meals provided by the team. Team members are NOT allowed to go off-site individually or in small groups for meals. Keeping the team together for group meals helps reduce costs and ensures all team members are available at short notice to assist the team. Group meal times will be announced to the team prior to the event and updated via Canvas during the day.

7.2.8. Dress Code

- Long hair must be tied back when working in the pit, near the robot, or with machinery to prevent entanglement.
- Jewelry is not acceptable if it can entangle into robot parts or into machinery, and is generally discouraged.
- Closed-toe shoes must be worn for work on the robot, machines, or in the pits. This applies to both in the shop and at competitions.

Regarding any apparel or gear with the team logo, keep the following in mind:

- When wearing a team shirt or carrying any piece of team gear, even if it is just at school, the Spartan Design VIQRC program and Stauffer Middle School are being represented.
- Shirts and other team gear may NOT be noticeably modified. For example, a leftover large team shirt being given to a petite student may be tailored; however, cutting off sleeves, lowering the neckline, or damaging any logos is not allowed.

Students must conduct themselves safely and professionally in the robotics lab, classroom, practice field, pits, and event venue.

- Use only tools for which you have received instruction and coach approval.
- Use cutting tools, powered equipment, chargers, and electrical devices only under the supervision required by the coach and school safety procedures.

7.2.9. Lab Behavior

the Spartan Design VIQRC program members are expected to conduct themselves in a professional and safe manner at all times while in the lab. This includes, but is not limited to, the following:

- Stop and ask for help when a tool, mechanism, battery, cable, or procedure is unfamiliar.
- Report damaged parts, tools, batteries, chargers, or field elements immediately.
- At the end of every work session, all tools and materials must be put away.
- When finished with a tool, it must be returned to its designated location.
- Ensure you are appropriately trained to use the tool/machine.
- If a tool/machine breaks, it must be reported to a mentor immediately.
- Keep food and open drinks away from robots, batteries, controllers, computers, chargers, field elements, and tools.
- If leaving before a work session is over, inform the Director(s), allocate at least 10 minutes to clean your work area, and announce the departure to a mentor prior to leaving. Mentors will help verify the workspace is cleaned prior to the team member leaving.
- If any spill occurs or material is dropped, it should be cleaned up immediately! If the spill creates a hazard, it should be announced clearly to all those around and a mentor should be informed immediately.
- Participate in a robotics-related activity while in the lab.
- Food should not be eaten within 10 feet of any machine or robotics assembly, especially when machines are in use!
- Leftover food or drink should be immediately disposed of.
- No intentional disruption or distraction of peers for the purpose of annoyance.
- No horseplay.

The points listed above are guidelines for behavior and not a complete list of expected conduct. Please discuss any questions or concerns with a Director, mentor, or Safety Captain.

In general, students should use common sense, protect one another, keep the workspace organized, and stop to ask for help whenever a task or condition is uncertain.

7.3. CONFIDENTIALITY AND RESPONSIBLE SHARING

Students may share approved team accomplishments and public event media, but must protect classmates' personal information, unpublished school information, account credentials, and any material the coach identifies as private. School and district media rules always apply.

7.4. COMMUNICATION

Official course communication occurs through Canvas and school email. Students should check Canvas on school days and respond to coach requests within the stated deadline.

7.4.1. Canvas and School Email

Canvas is the primary location for announcements, schedules, milestones, assignments, resources, and submissions. School email may be used for individual matters. Students are not required to use a personal social-media or chat account for the course.

- Canvas and school-email display names must use the student's recognizable school name.

7.4.2. Team Calendar

Students and families should use the Canvas course calendar as the official guide for class milestones, practices, events, and due dates. The coach will update it as information becomes available.

8. Student & Parent/Guardian Contract

Student and Parent/Guardian. Our signature below signifies that:

- We have read the Spartan Design VIQRC Competitive Elective Handbook and agree to follow its policies, safety requirements, team expectations, and current official competition rules.
- We understand the participation expectations and that travel or event attendance is a privilege subject to eligibility, readiness, safety, supervision, and school approval.
- We understand that Ms. Lang and school administration will use the procedures in this handbook and school policy when addressing concerns or determining activity eligibility.

Student. My signature signifies that:

- I understand the commitments required for my six-person team and will prepare for my assigned lead or backup role, shared construction, notebook work, and announced events.
- I will use robot-construction, charging, computer, and lab equipment only after safety instruction and with the required adult approval or supervision.
- I will keep my work area clean, put parts and tools away, protect batteries and electronics, and keep food and open drinks away from robotics work areas.
- I will listen to teammates, the coach, approved volunteers, and event officials and will practice respectful, student-centered conduct.
- I will arrive on time or provide appropriate notice of an absence and will help my lead/backup partner maintain team continuity.

Parent/Guardian. My signature signifies that:

- I understand that any media release or permission for the use of my student's name, image, work, or voice is governed by separate school and district forms; this handbook signature does not grant or replace those permissions.
- I will communicate safety, transportation, medical, scheduling, or participation concerns promptly through school-approved channels. Donations and volunteer service are appreciated but are not conditions of student membership.

Student Signature: _____ Date: _____

Parent/Guardian Signature: _____ Date: _____